

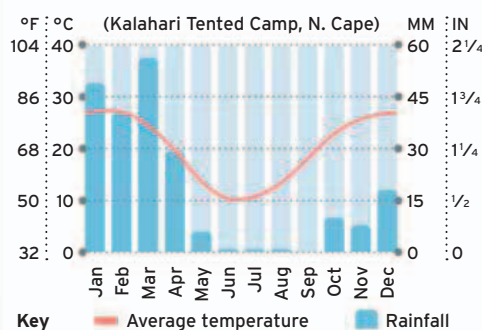
LOCATION

The Kalahari semiarid zone of Namibia, Botswana, and the northern Cape of South Africa is part of the larger Kalahari Basin.



CLIMATE

Extremely dry most of the year, with rain falling during the summer, but sometimes not at all. There are frequent night frosts in winter.



Caracal

Caracal caracal

short forelegs



Africa's second-largest small cat, the caracal can bring down prey up to three times its own size. Speed and agility allow it to run down faster animals such as hares and small antelopes, while powerful muscles in its long hind legs enable it to leap up to 10 ft (3 m) in the air to grab flying birds with its large front paws. The caracal's hunting skills so impressed Persian and Indian royalty that many were trained to hunt gamebirds for royal families.



- ↔ 2-4 ft (0.6-1.2 m)
- ⚖ 13-44 lb (6-20 kg)
- ⊗ Common
- 🦋 Birds, mammals
- 🏠 🌿 🌿 🌿



◀ EAR TUFTS

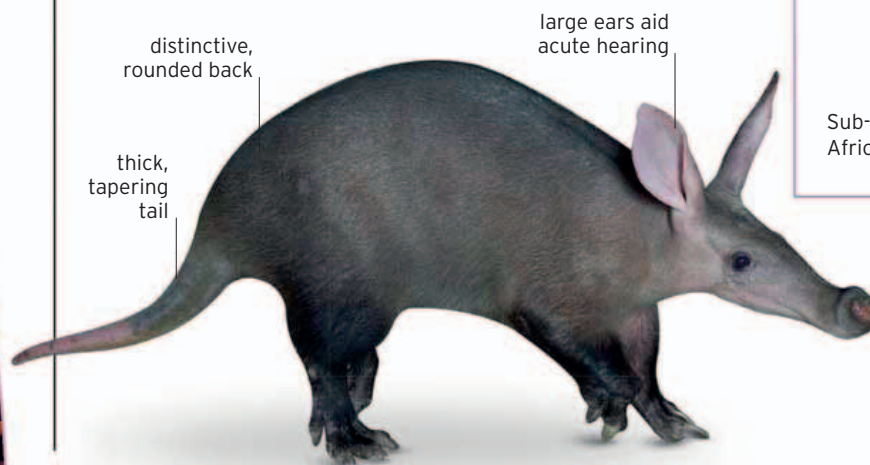
The long, black ear tufts may be used as protection against flies, camouflage in long grass, or even as a tool for communication.

Aardvark

Orycteropus afer

Short, stocky legs and a flattened snout inspired South Africa's Dutch settlers to give this mammal a name that means "earth pig." Yet the solitary, night-foraging aardvark is not related to pigs or even anteaters, though it feeds mainly on ants, using its long, sharp claws to tear into their mounds. It extracts the ants with its 12-in (30-cm) long, sticky tongue, and an adult can eat up to 50,000 in one night. The food is ground up by a muscular area of the aardvark's stomach.

- ↔ 3-5 ft (0.9-1.5 m)
- ⚖ 88-143 lb (40-65 kg)
- ⊗ Common
- 🦋 Ants, termites
- 🏠 🌿 🌿 🌿



◀ SUPER SNIFFER

An aardvark's nostrils close when feeding to protect its long snout, which contains specially adapted bones that enhance its sense of smell.

